

Srinagar, and the last in Jammu. The life of the Raina family was filled with struggles when they moved to Jammu from Kashmir. Being referred to as a refugee in his own country, Raina's classroom, when he was in the twelfth standard, happened to be a tent.

Such open schools were started by the authorities back in the day for people migrating to Jammu from Kashmir. However, this was just a small part of Raina's daily life. Struggling with finances, Raina's father was constantly advised by his new friends to employ his three kids (all sons) in order to meet the family expenses as he was the only one supporting a family of six, which included Raina's grandmother. Raina's father was of a different view altogether and wanted his sons to finish their education before they started working.

"I have never seen someone as committed as my father. Despite all the challenges and financial disabilities, he made sure all of us three brothers never had to compromise on education. He made it clear to all in the family that until we finished our schooling, none would even think of working. I am, and will always be, thankful for what he did for us. Those were the toughest times and I never saw my father complain about a single thing," explains Raina.

The Raina family used to live in a spacious house back in the days at Kashmir, and when they migrated to Jammu, all they could afford was an 8x8 room. The kids had to study in the same room where their mother cooked and grandmother rested. A lot of other families that had also migrated to Jammu had already started employing the sons of their families in order to survive financially. Raina's father, on the other hand, believed in long-term goals and was sure at all times that education was more necessary than being able to survive financially in the short term.

My father's message, in simple words, was, "Complete your education first and do whatever you want to do later on!"

Raina's childhood were those days when, forget OTT or the Internet, even getting a good reception of national TV channels run by the government was a mountainous task. He recollects that the only cartoon series he remembers from his childhood was the popular He-Man. He, sometimes with his brothers and sometimes alone, used to go to a neighbour's house every Sunday to watch it.

He says, "I remember vaguely that the intro of this cartoon happened to be a statement like The Master of the Universe," and Raina today has truly become a master of his trade!

"There was not a single comic series available in Kashmir back then. Owning a TV was like leading a super luxurious life. We had to go to a neighbour's house to see the series every Sunday," Raina's eyes sparkled as he recalled those precious moments from his teenage years watching He-Man, and while he saw some other cartoon series as well, this is the only one he remembers clearly.

Sholay, the iconic blockbuster Bollywood film, also brings back cherishable memories for Raina. His family owned a tape-recorder (the one that plays audio cassette tapes), and Raina would play the audio cassette of Sholay every now and then. Raina, who has never seen the movie even once on a TV, remembers all its dialogues from just listening to it on the tape-recorder!

Raina explains that the biggest turning point of his life was the ability to read and write in English. His endeavours to learn the language included reading newspapers, magazines, and watching news broadcasts in the English language.

"There came a time when publications started printing my articles written in English. I think the hard work around English has played a big role in my success story," he says.

Blending history, mythology, and politics into communications

Although Raina watched some cartoons on TV in his childhood, he has completely given up on watching TV now. Books around history, mythology, and politics are what satiate his entertainment needs. In fact, Raina was active in politics during his college days, and was one of the most well-known student leaders in Jammu. The only shows he has watched, or plans to watch, are around history, ancient kingdoms, and how these were ruled back in the day.

"What excites me is the way ancient kings managed their kingdoms. The history of different people and different communities helps me understand our race better. If I am not watching anything on the history front, I turn to war movies. These again help one understand the strategies that make one the winning side and the other the losing side," says Raina.

Raina is a keen reader and has read most of the religious books that exist today. The list of religious books that he has read include *The Holy Quran*, *The Bible*, *The Bhagavad Gita*, and many others. Apart from the business and marketing books, you will also find a lot of mythology books placed on Raina's bookshelf.

"There are a lot of stereotypes in your head that are usually imposed by society. You are always told that whatever is there is the right thing. Sometimes religion prohibits you from exploring 'the point of view' of others. Doesn't everyone exist like the way you exist on this planet?" explains Raina.

He adds, "The books around history, religions, mythology, and war help me understand things and people in a much better way. These helped me break those stereotypes in my head. Believe it or not, these books to me are the way towards learning about human psychology. I have been a communications guy and these books give you a lot of insights into how humans behave."